

sciousness. They were so vividly pushed into my mind by unseen forces that my fingers tapped them out in capitals:

ULTIMATELY, NOTHING MATTERS.

I do not know how to explain what followed, so I shall attempt no explanation. Perhaps it was coincidence; perhaps not.

At any rate, on that same typewriter, a short time later, I worked on a message which I helped Woodrow Wilson write. Had the message been made public at the time, it would have changed the entire course of World War I. Certainly it seemed this message *mattered*.

Three days after the Armistice was signed, I saw a newspaper lying in the gutter. Its front page bore a facsimile of the message. Did it matter? It had become utterly valueless with the lapse of a few days. With a shock of recognition my mind filled with the thought: *Ultimately, nothing matters.*

Some time passed. Woodrow Wilson became the guiding spirit behind the great new League of Nations. He believed that the future of civilization depended on the United States Senate's ratification. The Senate would not ratify. Mr. Wilson took to his bed, and no matter what bulletins the doctors issued, we who were close to him knew he was dying of heart-break and despair.

I came to his bedside. He looked at me hopelessly and murmured: "Those men on Capitol Hill have killed me."

Neither he nor I could say at that time that the world was not ready for the League of Nations plan. Yet something prompted me to say what might have been considered unfitting—and turned out to be the best words I could have said.

"Mr. President," I said, "ultimately, nothing matters."

He looked at me with a strange, slowly comprehending expression and finally said: "Of course not!"

Perhaps I helped him pass more peacefully into death. I know that the phrase has stayed strongly with me since, and I feel it was not of my own invention—it was placed in my mind by unseen, wiser powers who wished me to have it at that point in my life.

Nothing matters ultimately, so why fill your life with fear? Often I have noticed men and women who go through life afraid of this and afraid of that—as though they had tuned